an impending attack on the camp. We would stay thus, half-dressed, with one shoe on and one shoe off, until daybreak. A thorough search of the area next morning would sometimes reveal the carcass of a deer or leopard as the cause of all the excitement. If a deer, it was brought back to the camp and used to supplement our rations.

Sometime in betwixt, Major Adolf S. Pinto, of 10 SIKHLI, was posted to the unit. He became the Company Commander of Bravo Company, and I reverted to my Captain's rank to become his Company 2iC. Pinto, although just a year or so senior to me, had an excellent grasp of Company administration and I learnt a lot from him, which came in handy later when I became a full-fledged and permanent Company Commander. Pinto and Subedar Faqir Singh, the Senior JCO, ran a tight ship. Faqir, as his name suggested, was a quiet and saintly type of person who never allowed anyone to put a foot wrong. No question of any human rights (HR) violations as long as Faqir Sahib was around. Subedar (Hony Capt) Faqir Singh worked on a tulip farm post-retirement, and we stayed in touch even after I had left Lucky Seven. Faqir Sahib passed away in 2021, and this is my tribute to him.

One fallout of my reverting to Captain was that I could now be spared to study for and appear for the DSSC exam. Accordingly, I proceeded for the pre-staff preparatory course, followed by two months of annual leave, culminating in the exam in the first week of April 1990. I did not know it then, when I left for the pre-staff, that I would not be returning to the Emerald Isle.

Under relentless pressure from the IPKF, the LTTE formulated a new strategy, entering into a ceasefire with the SLA. They were cunningly able to convince the Sri Lankan government that this was an internal affair of theirs that they

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